



ShabbaTTogether

Inclusive Tu B'Shvat Children's Activities for Hebrew Schools and Preschools

Note for 2023: This program has NOT been adapted for virtual programming. There are great activities and handouts here that can easily be adapted for virtual programming and emailed to families in advance. Please use the info below in whichever way will best suit the current needs of your community.

Tu B'Shvat is naturally connected with the concept of inclusion. As we celebrate that Hashem creates so many different types of trees, plants and fruits for our use and enjoyment, we celebrate that there are all kinds of people in the world, each person with a specific purpose and each one precious.

Man is intrinsically connected to all of creation, and is compared to a tree. For man is a tree in the field - Devarim, 20:19. Each person, regardless of age, ability, or any other identifying characteristic, is compared to a tree. Tu B'Shvat is an opportunity to teach that we all are created in the image of Hashem and that Hashem created us all different so we can each fulfill our own special mission.

This guide has ideas for celebrating Tu B'Shvat with your Hebrew School or preschool with an inclusive theme. The activities are a mix of activities that appeal to a wide range of abilities, and ones that explicitly teach inclusion concepts.

The guide includes:

1. Guided Fruit Tasting
2. Tu B'Shvat Stretches
3. Poem Reading
4. Crafts
5. General Tu B'Shvat Activities
6. Resources

1. Guided Fruit Tasting

Goal: Eat as many of the Shivas Haminim as possible and connect the tasting to inclusive Torah concepts.

Materials:

- Shivas Haminim and/or any available fruit
- A shehecheyanu fruit (optional)
- Serving utensils and paper goods
- [Discussion guide sheet](#)

Notes: This may be used as an individual class activity, or as part of a larger Tu B'Shvat Seder.

Have students taste each fruit. You can have them guess which fruit they will taste next by giving hints. Have as many of the Sheva Minim as possible.

Use the Guide for Fruit Tasting to discuss inclusion concepts connected with Tu B'Shvat.

For information on the deeper meaning of the Sheva Minim, [click here](#).

2. Tu B'Shvat Stretches

Goal: Utilize physical movement within your program as a hands-on way to help children of all abilities to stay focused and participate.

Materials: [Click here for The 5 Tu B'Shvat Stretches guide](#)

Notes: While physical movement is necessary and beneficial for everyone, it can be particularly useful in helping children with a variety of developmental differences stay engaged in group activities.

3. Poem Reading

Goal: Learn the Chassidic meaning of the parts of a tree as well as a lesson in inclusion.

Materials: [Click here for Poem Handout](#)

Notes: Students take turns reading the poem, or a group of students can present the poem to the rest of the Hebrew School. For pre readers, read the poem out loud.

4. Crafts

Goal: Utilize art to support the inclusive message that everyone is of great value.

Materials: [Click here for two crafts ideas](#) - a butcher paper mitzvah tree and framed leaf art.

Notes: The Mitzvah Tree is a craft where children create a large tree made of butcher paper that can then be used for mitzvah notes. After Tu B'Shvat, this tree can be used to post mitzvah notes of the students being inclusive or kind to others.

The Framed Leaf Art shows the beauty of the diversity of different plants and leaves. It brings home the message that we are all different and together, we make a beautiful world.

5. General Tu B'Shvat Activities and Resources

Goal: Provide general activities and resources that can be used with a wide range of ages and abilities.

Materials: [Click here for Activity and Resource List.](#)

Notes: While not strictly inclusive, these activities are universal - ready to be enjoyed by a wide group of people. Having fun together is an opportunity to create social connections that are important for everyone, and especially important for those who may have difficulty building friendships.